How to ask and answer questions (Guhr 2021[2])

How do you ask/answer questions about a talk appropriately?

In the context of a talk or panel discussion at a conference, or in an academic context in general, it is common to take questions from the audience after the finished talk or after/during a panel discussion.

Here is your chance on the one hand to ask questions that have come to you during the talk or that you have already asked yourself in your preparation for the talk. Short comments, feedback, remarks, suggestions are also often welcome, as long as they are formulated constructively, positively and support the progress of the discussion as well as enrich the question session.

Be brave! Especially from students and young academics, questions are welcome. It is also a good opportunity to draw attention to yourself, prepare for a follow-up conversation during the coffee break and make new contacts.

Scenario A: You are sitting in the audience of a talk/panel discussion.

1) Start with a short thank you to the speaker

(for panel discussion to chair and participating speakers)

"First of all, thank you very much for this XXX (appropriate adjective, e.g. inspiring) talk / panel discussion / argumentation / passionate exchange of views."

2) Briefly state your name and university for attribution of your person

"I am XY from the TU Darmstadt."

3a) Formulate your question(s) briefly (max. 1 main sentence + 1 subordinate clause per question)

"During your talk, the following question came to my mind: XY?

Important:

Avoid long introductions for your questions.

Make sure it is really a question and not a statement with rising intonation at the end of the sentence or attached "or?".

Ask yourself in advance:

Is it possible to answer the question in max. 5-8 sentences or would it make more sense to formulate a question that is shorter to answer and thus establish contact/starting point for a subsequent discussion in the coffee break.

3b) If you have several questions, ask them in a structured way (but never more than 2 short questions!)

"During your presentation, 2 questions came to my mind that I would like to ask you.
My first question is: xxxx?
My second question is: xxxx?"

Important:

Never ask more than 2 questions at the same time so that the other listeners still have time to ask questions.

Save your further questions in case there are no more questions from others, or for continuing a conversation in the coffee break afterwards.

3c) Ask questions about a specific slide or point in the presentation

Make sure you have written down the slide number or the slide title during the talk so that you can refer to it specifically.

"I would like to ask a question about slide number XY. Could you possibly point it out again? (Wait briefly for a reaction and then formulate your question with reference to the slide). On your slide you refer to XY. Could you please go into more detail about point XY. It was not clear to me what XY means.

3d) Ask presenter(s) for a short statement

"During your presentation a thought occurred to me on which I would like to hear your opinion."

Important:

Only ask for comments if you are sure that the answer can be formulated in less than 10 sentences. Longer statements belong in the coffee break.

3e) Give constructive criticism

"I noticed on slide XY that you used XY / that you did XY. Did you ever consider doing XY in such and such a way?
How did the decision to do XY so and so come about? Have you already tried YZ or do you still plan to try YZ?”

Important:

Make sure you formulate your criticism constructively, i.e. with concrete suggestions for possible solutions. It is always depressing to be confronted only with the weak points and challenges of your project. Most of the time, these weak points are already known to the speaker. Formulate your criticism positively and always ask yourself how you would like to be confronted with criticism of your weak points in a question session.

3f) Take a stand yourself

If you yourself would like to comment on what has been said/presented, because you are researching/are well versed in the topic and thus would like to stimulate a follow-up discussion for the coffee break. Make sure that your comment enriches the question session and possibly stimulates other listeners to ask questions.

"I would like to make a brief comment on point XY and would be happy to discuss this point with you again during the coffee break. (Statement in maximum 5 sentences follows)."

4) Thank you for answering the question

(often the speaker asks if the question was answered satisfactorily).

"Yes, thank you very much. (That helped me a lot / Now I understand it better)."

Scenario B: You receive questions after your presentation or during/after a panel discussion

1) Listen carefully to the question, take notes if necessary

On the one hand, write down keywords from the question asked and on the other hand, also write down the keywords that first come to your mind while listening to the question.

At the same time, try to maintain eye contact. This is particularly challenging.

2) Structure the answer mentally

Do not panic. Use the key words of the question as a guide to structure your answer. Do not answer too quickly. Everyone in the plenary is comfortable waiting for your answer so that you have time to think. The plenary prefers well-structured and thoughtful answers rather than impulsive or incomplete ones.

Go ahead:

3) Thanking the person for asking the question and thereby showing interest in your talk.

"Thank you very much for your question."

4) Answer the question

4a) Answer question directly

"I would like to answer your question: xxxxxxx."

"I hope to be able to answer your question. In my opinion / My opinion / I think it is xxxxx."

4b) Rephrase the question

If you are not immediately sure how you want to answer, you can give yourself more time and create structure by repeating the question asked in your own words and in a structured way.
"I hope I have understood you correctly. You are asking if xxxx, is that correct?" (waiting for reaction in the audience) then answer question as indicated in (4a).

4c) The answer to the asked question would be too long for the framework of the question session.

"You are addressing a complex phenomenon, / your question concerns a known complex challenge of the project, which we are welcome to discuss further in the coffee break afterwards. To give a short answer, I think xxxxxxxx." then answer question partially as indicated in (4a).

4d) You cannot answer the question

There will always be times when you cannot answer a question spontaneously. That is absolutely fine. No one expects you to be omniscient and especially under the pressure of the question-answer situation, no one will be annoyed with you if you cannot answer a question. Nevertheless, you have to respond to the question.
"This is a point of view I have not dealt with before. / Unfortunately, I'm not that far advanced with my research in the area, but I will write down your question and if you give me your email address during the coffee break, I will contact you as soon as I find out more details about your question."
Or: Play the ball back and gain constructive feedback with problem-solving suggestions from the unpleasant question.
"You are right, this is an important point that I have neglected so far. Do you possibly already have ideas/conceptions on how this challenge or XY could be addressed?"

4e) Responding to negative criticism

Negative criticism always feels frustrating, especially if it is not formulated constructively. There are (at least) two types of negative criticism:
(1) Well-founded negative criticism on your incomplete research or presentation
It is always possible and understandable that you make small mistakes during a presentation. *Errare humanum est. ;)*
Most of the time, you will only notice them retrospectively, long after the presentation is over. It is important that you admit your mistakes when asked by the audience and correct them. Picking up on a recognised mistake can also be inserted between questions as a short comment by the presenter.

(2) (less frequent!) Unfounded negative criticism due to the ignorance of the person asking the question (less frequent!)

Nevertheless, it is also possible that the person who made the negative criticism misunderstood your presentation. Always be friendly, understanding and offer to explain the criticised aspect in more detail during the coffee break. This kind of response shows research maturity and will impress the plenary.

5) Ask if the question has been answered

"I hope this has roughly answered your question?" (Wait for reaction, possibly they will ask a further question).

6) Expressing brief thanks at the end of the question session as a conclusion to the presentation

"I would like to thank you very much for your attention as well as for the constructive feedback and your stimulating questions and I hope that we will continue to talk about one or the other point during the coffee break."

Checklist 1

You are in the plenary asking questions:

- Thank you for your talk
- Short Self-introduction
- Question: short, structured, can be answered in a few sentences:
    - Structure your questions to make it easier for the addressee to give his/her answer
    - Make sure your question can be answered in a few sentences
    - Avoid long introductions to your questions
    - Avoid long statements of your own
- Thank the addressee for answering your question

Don'ts when asking questions:

- Asking question(s) but not listening or showing no reaction when answering.
- Long introductions before the question
- Ask more than 2 questions at a time
- Long statements that do not enrich the discussion but rather disturb it
- Express negative criticism without constructive suggestions

Checklist 2

You are in the speaker answering questions:

- Thank you for asking the question
- Pick up on the key words of the question asked
- If necessary, honestly admit lack of knowledge
- Ask back questions if necessary
- Ask whether the question has been answered
- Thank for questions, feedback, suggestions, hints

Don'ts when answering questions:

- If you don't know what you're talking about, beat around the bush without answering the question. (this does no one any good and you miss the chance to get possible solutions from the questioner)
- Look for excuses in the face of negative criticism instead of standing by one's decisions and justifying them scientifically
- React unfriendly to negative criticism